

Reading the Block Trades Panel

A working guide to `ticker-block-trades.pine` — what the columns mean, what they don't, and how Barry Burns says to use them.

Indicator: `/Users/henryoliver/Projects/Trading/pinescript-indicators/ticker-block-trades.pine` · Companion: `ticker-tape.pine` · Pine v6, sub-pane, live data only · 14 Aug 2026

1 · What this pane actually plots

Column height = how many individual prints on that bar were $\geq$ your size threshold. Not cumulative bar volume. Not dollars. A count of large orders.

That distinction is the whole point. Barry's words: *"it's a little different than just watching volume in how many contracts or shares are being traded on any given bar, because that is just the cumulative volume of any given bar — but it doesn't tell us what the size of each particular trade is. And when we know the size of each particular trade, that's a hint as to who is trading."*

A bar with 400,000 shares of retail dribble and a bar with 400,000 shares in four institutional blocks look identical on a normal volume histogram. Here the first is empty and the second is a column of 4. You are looking at **who**, not **how much**.

THE ONE-LINE READ

Height tells you how many pros showed up. Color tells you which side they were on and whether they were in a hurry. Everything else in this document is detail on those two axes.

2 · Barry's four-step read — and where the panel answers each

From *"How to know if the volume is professional or amateur"*, Barry gives four questions in order. The panel is built to answer all four at a glance:

#	BARRY'S QUESTION	WHERE YOU READ IT ON THIS PANE
1	How large are the orders?	Your <code>Block Size Threshold</code> input decides this before the chart draws. Nothing under it is ever counted. This is the single most consequential setting — see §5.
2	How many large orders are there?	Column height. Also <code>Block Total (this bar)</code> in the Data Window / status line. Barry: <i>"some of those volume bars are higher than others — that's where more professional trades are coming in."</i>
3	At what price level do they come in?	Read the column <i>against the price bar directly above it</i> . This is why the pane is stacked under price rather than off to the side. §6 is entirely about this step.
4	Above the ask, or below the bid?	Column color. Two hues (side) $\times$ two tiers (aggression). This is the step almost nobody does, and it's the one the color encoding exists for.

(sources: `10-volume-obv-block-trades-a.txt`, `10-volume-obv-block-trades-b.txt`)

3 · The color code — read it in one glance

Cyan is the buy side. Red is the sell side. Within each side, the **brighter/more opaque** tier means aggressive — someone reached *through* the quote to get filled. The **fainter** tier means passive — size sat *at* the quote and waited.

COLUMN COLOR	WHAT THE PRINTS DID	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
 Aggressive Buy (bright cyan)	Blocks printed <i>above</i> the ask	Someone is lifting offers with size . They're willing to pay up. Barry: " <i>they're stretching — willing to pay a little more than normal.</i> " This is the most urgent buy-side reading on the pane.
 At Ask (faint cyan)	Blocks printed <i>at</i> the ask	Buy-side interest, no urgency . Institutional accumulation without chasing. Supportive, not a trigger.
 At Bid (faint red)	Blocks printed <i>at</i> the bid	Sell-side interest, no urgency. Distribution without panic.
 Aggressive Sell (bright red)	Blocks printed <i>below</i> the bid	Someone is hitting bids with size — accepting a worse price to get out or get short now. Most urgent sell-side reading.
 Mid / Neutral (gray)	Mid-spread prints, or buy and sell exactly balanced	Big money traded, no directional information . Common on dark-pool / mid-point crosses. Treat the height as noise until something else confirms.

HOW THE BAR PICKS ITS ONE COLOR

Side is decided by **net delta** (at-ask + above-ask) – (at-bid + below-bid). Tier is then decided *within the winning side only*: if aggressive prints ≥ passive prints on that side, you get the bright tier. Ties go to aggressive. **The losing side contributes nothing to the color** — a 6-buy / 5-sell bar and a 6-buy / 0-sell bar are the same cyan. If the balance matters to you, read [Block Net Delta](#) in the Data Window, not the color.

Faded columns near the close

With `De-emphasize Into the Close` on (default), any bar inside **15:30–16:00 ET** is drawn washed out. Block spikes in that window are overwhelmingly position-squaring and index rebalancing — mechanical flow, not opinion. **A faded column is not a signal**. The fade is relative, so it works at any transparency you set.

4 · The seven crosshair readouts

The column is a summary. The numbers are the actual read. Hover any bar and the status line / Data Window gives you seven values, in this fixed order — identical names and order to `ticker-tape.pine`, so the two can be read side by side without translating.

READOUT	READ IT AS
Block Buy (aggressive)	Prints above the ask. Urgency to own.
Block At Ask	Prints at the ask. Patient accumulation.
Block At Bid	Prints at the bid. Patient distribution.
Block Sell (aggressive)	Prints below the bid. Urgency to exit.
Block Mid / Neutral	Mid-spread. Size with no side.
Block Total (this bar)	The column height. Barry's step 2.
Block Net Delta	The bar's lean in one signed number. Buy-side minus sell-side. This is the number to actually watch.

WHY THE BREAKDOWN MATTERS MORE THAN THE HEIGHT

A bar of five at-ask blocks and a bar of five hit-the-bid blocks are **the same column height and opposite information**. Never read height alone. Height says "pros were here"; the breakdown says what they did.

Reading combinations that actually mean something

High total, high positive net delta, aggressive tier Strongest single-bar read on the pane. Multiple pros paying up simultaneously. Weight it heavily <i>if</i> it lands at a location from §6.	High total, net delta near zero Two-sided battle at size — a transfer of ownership. Often marks a turning point but tells you nothing about which way. Wait for the resolution bar.
Low total (1–2), aggressive tier One trader in a hurry. Barry: <i>"just because one professional comes in and trades doesn't necessarily mean it's going to be a winner."</i> Low weight on its own.	Rising totals over consecutive bars, one-sided The most reliable pattern here. Barry's <i>"preponderance of the evidence"</i>: <i>"wait a minute, we're getting quite a few professionals coming in."</i> Sustained beats spiky.
Mostly gray, big totals Crossing/dark-pool prints. Real money, invisible intent. Do not infer direction from it.	Empty pane at a clean setup Not a veto. See §8 — Barry is explicit that good setups happen with no professional volume, often because the pros are already positioned.

5 • Set it up correctly, once

Three settings determine whether what you're reading is real. Get these wrong and you will be diagnosing a bug that isn't one.

- 1 **Block Size Threshold — tune this per symbol, by trial and error.** The script's default is **1,000** (the tape's institutional floor, which keeps the pane populated on normal symbols). **Barry's own numbers are higher:** stocks **10,000 shares bare minimum** for any stock; ES/YM futures **20+ contracts**; E-minis he typically sets at **100**; Nasdaq futures **50**. His tuning rule: raise it until block spikes start landing at meaningful spots — cycle highs/lows and breakouts. If the pane is a wall of columns on every bar, the threshold is too low and you are counting retail. If it's empty for hours, it's too high.

Barry's logic for the number: "an average amateur trader — how much are they trading? One contract, maybe two, three, four, perhaps 20 — not so likely." Set it above what an amateur would ever do on your symbol.

- 2 **Intrabar History Bars must EQUAL Ticker Tape's setting.** Both default to **500**. This is a hard coverage window, not a performance hint — bars older than it get no tick data at all and count as **zero**, not "unknown." Run the panel at 100 against a tape at 500 and every bar from 101 back shows squares on the tape and nothing here. That is not a timing bug; it's two different windows.
- 3 **Kill the pane's bottom margin.** Right-click this pane's price scale → *Settings...* → *Margins* → **Bottom = 0%**. TradingView pads every pane ~10%, which is what puts a phantom "-1" gridline under a count that can never be negative. It's a pane setting, unreachable from Pine. One-time fix.
- 4 **Scale Maximum** (default 10) sets the pane's floor-to-ceiling range when things are quiet, so bar heights stay comparable across bars instead of rescaling to whatever is on screen. Busier bars push the top up — **nothing is ever clipped**. Raise it on heavy symbols or low thresholds; lower it to magnify a thin tape.
- 5 **Match the threshold to the tape's** if you want the columns and the squares to agree print-for-print. They share a byte-identical classifier, so with equal thresholds and equal history bars the numbers cannot drift.

6 · Where to look — Barry's two locations

Barry is unambiguous about this. Block trades are not a scanning tool you stare at all day. **You look for them in two places:**

BARRY'S EXPLICIT RULE

"Look for these in two places. Number one, cycle highs and cycle lows. Number two, breakouts — breakouts through support/resistance."

At cycle highs and cycle lows

Stack this pane next to your stochastic. When the cycle turns *and* a one-sided block column prints at the extreme, you have two energies agreeing. Barry's walkthrough: *"we got a lot of big trades coming in — and where's it coming in? Right at that cycle low."* A cycle low with aggressive-buy blocks is a different animal from a cycle low with an empty pane.

On breakouts through support/resistance

This is the highest-value use of the pane, and it's the fix for the most common retail problem — false breakouts.

Barry: *"if a breakout isn't accompanied by professional traders, it's probably not going to follow through."* Two reasons he gives: (1) the smart money isn't trading it, so it's probably not a smart trade; (2) professional volume **itself creates the momentum** that sustains the move. The blocks aren't just evidence of the move — they're part of the mechanism.

Practical: mark your level. When price takes it out, look down. A breakout bar with aggressive-tier blocks in the breakout direction is a different trade from a breakout bar with an empty pane or, worse, blocks leaning the *opposite* way (someone selling into your breakout).

The setup it confirms best: the second retrace in the trend

Barry's own worked example stacks it onto a wave-4 entry: trend up, second retrace, price at the 15 EMA, cycle low, two-bar candlestick pattern — *and* professional volume. His summary of what you're doing: **"preponderance of the evidence."** The blocks are one piece of that case, never the case itself.

BARRY'S EXPLICIT CAUTION

"This one thing alone will not make you money. It's another piece of evidence to put together to build a case for taking a trade." And on tracking institutions specifically: *"the whales know we're trying to track them and they don't want to be tracked — they're constantly hiding their orders across various markets, various exchanges, different sizes, different times."* You are not tracking whales. You are filtering for accounts big enough that the odds say they're profitable.

7 · When the panel and the tape disagree

Three causes, all expected, none a bug — the classifier is byte-identical between the two files and enforced by `scripts/sync-block-engine.sh`.

SYMPTOM

CAUSE

Older bars show squares on the tape, nothing here	Different coverage windows. Your two <code>Intrabar History Bars</code> settings aren't equal. This is the one that looks most like a timing bug. Fix: make them match.
Tape shows squares only on the forming bar	The tape's squares default to <code>Keep History = 0</code> . Its per-bar numbers still populate the Data Window across the whole window — compare with the crosshair, not with the squares.
Tape shows 25 squares, panel shows a column of 40	The tape caps drawn squares at 25 per bar (<code>BLOCK_SQUARE_MAX</code>). Its <i>counts</i> stay exact past that; only the drawing stops. Both are correct.

8 • Known limits — read these before you trust a reading

LIVE DATA ONLY

1-tick data exists only inside the intrabar window and fills on realtime/recent bars. **This pane cannot be back-tested over deep history.** An empty pane on last month's chart means no data, not no blocks. Judge the tool on live sessions or not at all.

THE ~1,002 TICK-PER-BAR FEED CAP

TradingView serves at most ~1,002 ticks per bar. On a busier minute the array pins at the cap and the count stops rising mid-bar. **It undercounts rather than lying** — but on a fast open, a column that looks "merely large" may be much larger. If capping matters on your symbol, drop to a lower chart timeframe.

REAL PRINTS ONLY — NO FALLBACK

The old volume-delta approximation (treating an aggregate $\geq$ threshold as a "block" when no live 1T stream exists) was removed on 2026-08-10. A dead feed now shows an **empty tape and an empty panel**, not two different guesses. If both are blank, suspect the feed before you conclude the pros are absent.

ABSENCE IS NOT A VETO

Barry walks through a textbook first-retrace setup with *zero* professional volume on it, and takes it. His explanation: pros aren't always trading the same signals you are, and often *"they're already in — they got in early"* at the trend reversal. **Blocks add confidence when present. Their absence removes confidence, it does not invalidate a setup.**

STYLE-TAB CAVEAT

Blockless bars plot `na`, not 0 — deliberately, so the baseline stays bare instead of drawing a solid line of zero-height stubs. Consequence: if you restyle to *Line* or *Area*, the trace **breaks** at every blockless bar. That's the trade for a clean baseline. The count is event data, not a continuous series — leave it on Histogram.

9 • The 10-second read, in order

- 1 **Is there a column at all?** No column = no institutional prints on that bar. Move on; don't invent meaning.
- 2 **How tall relative to its neighbors?** You're reading relative size, not an absolute number. One block is context; six is a statement.

- 3 **What color — which side, which tier?** Bright = someone reached through the quote. Faint = someone waited. Gray = no information.
- 4 **Is it faded?** Faded = inside 15:30–16:00 ET = position-squaring. Discount it.
- 5 **Look up: where in price did it land?** At a cycle extreme? On a breakout through a level? Nowhere in particular? **Location is what converts a column into evidence.**
- 6 **Crosshair for Block Net Delta** if the color alone isn't enough — it's the only readout that shows you the *margin*, not just the winner.
- 7 **Add it to the case, don't build the case on it.** Trend, cycle, momentum, S/R first. Blocks are the confirming vote.

10 · What this pane will never tell you

- **Who** traded. Institutions deliberately fragment orders across venues and times. You are filtering by size, not identifying counterparties.
- **Whether the pro is right.** Barry: *"professional traders have losers too. I lose sometimes."*
- **Intent.** A large sell block may be a hedge, an unwind, a rebalance, or a directional bet. You see the print, not the reason.
- **Direction, when the prints are mid-spread.** Gray means gray.
- **Anything at all on deep history.** Live window only.

Methodology sources: `10-volume-obv-block-trades-a.txt`, `10-volume-obv-block-trades-b.txt` (Top Dog Trading — Dr. Barry Burns).

Implementation source: `ticker-block-trades.pine` · shared classifier synced from `ticker-tape.pine` via `scripts/sync-block-engine.sh`.

Teaching reference only — not trading advice and not a signal service.